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‘We’re getting stonewalled’

Aldermen blast Bally’s for construction halt, casino says City Council sparked the pause

By **Jake Sheridan**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago aldermen were frustrated Wednesday at a lack of answers as they sharply questioned and criticized top representatives of the Bally’s Chicago casino amid a construction slowdown on the \$1.7 billion River West project.

City Council members probed the embattled company’s finances

and grilled executives over the early-August decision to pause building a hotel and nearly all other non-gambling amenities at the site.

But critics of the pause complained they couldn’t get straight information from casino leaders or Mayor Brandon Johnson’s top deputies during the License and Consumer Protection Committee meeting.

“We’re getting stonewalled top

to bottom,” said downtown Ald. Brendan Reilly, 42nd, who accused Johnson of failing to enforce the city’s contract with Bally’s to maintain construction. “We’re allowing folks to play games with union jobs, people’s livelihoods and, honestly, our police and fire pensions, which require this casino to be incredibly successful.”

And committee Chair Ald. Debra Silverstein said it was “very disappointing, very embarrassing, very insulting, any adjective you can

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Right: Ald. Brendan Reilly, 42nd, gets frustrated with the answers to his questions from Bally’s Corp. representatives during a committee hearing at Chicago City Hall on Wednesday discussing Bally’s decision to stall construction on their River West casino. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



A person walks atop a concrete median that leads up to the Cortland Street Bridge over the Chicago River on Sept. 2.
CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A PRECIOUS LANDMARK OR TRAFFIC ALBATROSS?

Aldermen want Cortland Street Bridge’s status revoked, an effort spurned by preservation advocates

By **Talia Soglin**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Cortland Street Bridge has been closed to vehicles for the last year, lengthening drives across the river, snarling bus commutes and generating a daily mess of traffic North Side residents describe as a “huge inconvenience” and a “total nightmare.”

The 124-year-old bridge — which predates Daniel Burnham’s Plan of Chicago, the construction of Wrigley Field and the publication of Upton Sinclair’s “The Jungle” — is also a protected city landmark. It’s said to be the

oldest model of a trunnion bascule bridge, an iconic movable bridge design native to Chicago’s landscape. The Chicago Department of Transportation shut the bridge down a year ago for what officials said would be an 18- to 24-month-long rehabilitation project.

But with the bridge in worse shape than previously thought and its closure now indefinite, two fed-up aldermen told the Tribune they want to revoke its city landmark status in hopes of speeding up the process toward a new, functional bridge at Cortland Street. CDOT, meanwhile, cautioned that removing its city

landmark status wouldn’t eliminate the need for state or federal historical review of planned work on the bridge.

The aldermen’s push, spurned by historical preservation advocates, highlights an urban philosophical debate: What’s a city to do when its architectural heritage and aging infrastructure are one and the same?

When CDOT shut the Cortland bridge down last September, officials estimated it would reopen sometime in 2027. But now, CDOT says a structural assessment of the bridge has revealed it’s not capable of safely carrying vehicle traffic,

necessitating “more extensive” work than originally anticipated. The effort, CDOT said, is now expected to last multiple years, and various options are on the table — including replacing the historic bridge entirely.

Ald. Brian Hopkins, who represents the 2nd Ward and would like to see the bridge de-landmarked, described the situation as “an abdication of duty” by CDOT.

“Their job is to make sure people can get from point A to point B,” said Hopkins, who

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Judge must untangle questions in Burge cases

Some of them may end up back under purview of the state’s attorney

By **Madeline Buckley**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For more than two decades, the Cook County state’s attorney’s office has been conflicted from handling certain cases involving former Chicago police Cmdr. Jon Burge or detectives working under him, with an outside prosecutor or other agencies stepping in to try the cases instead.

But more than 30 years after Burge was fired from the Chicago Police Department as allegations of torture began to come to light, some cases may end up back under the purview of State’s Attorney Eileen O’Neill Burke — though not before a judge untangles knotty questions about whether a conflict of interest still remains.

Even though Burge died nearly eight years ago, the long tentacles of the scandal continue to reverberate at the Leighton Criminal Court Building, where defendants alleging that they were tortured continue to fight for their innocence.

The most recent issue has emerged because Robert Milan, a special prosecutor handling a number of the cases, has informed the court that he would like to withdraw after he was appointed in 2017 to oversee the cases in lieu of the county’s top prosecutor.

In his motion to withdraw, Milan wrote that the “Cook County state’s attorney’s office ... is ready, willing and able to assume prosecutorial responsibility for each of these cases.”

But the court filing set off a flurry of motions and hearings before Judge Erica Reddick, the presiding judge of the court’s criminal division, as some attorneys cited concern over how the change would impact ongoing cases and whether or not a conflict still precluded Cook County prosecutors from handling

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INSIDE

Weiss loses its state hospital license

Weiss Memorial Hospital has lost its Illinois hospital license, even as its owners and community leaders continue to discuss plans to reopen the facility. **Business**

White Sox have 3 join 30-HR club

 Charting the path to 30 home runs for the White Sox trio of Miguel Vargas, Colson Montgomery and Munetaka Murakami. **Sports**



Workers set up Tuesday for the convention in American Airlines Center in Dallas. **SHELBY TAUBER/THE NEW YORK TIMES**

Aides say Trump poised to become more visible

Trips slated to help GOP candidates after party’s rally in Dallas

By **Maggie Haberman**
THE NEW YORK TIMES

President Donald Trump is poised to become far more visible outside the White House than he has been for most of his term, starting with a Republican midterms convention in Texas and continuing with travel to boost candidates, according to his aides.

If the president expands his domestic travel after the two-day gathering in Dallas that began Wednesday, it will be a test of whether he still has the ability to connect to the concerns of voters, something that helped him win the 2016 and 2024 elections.

His effort was complicated after he plunged the United States even deeper into a series of costly global conflicts this week, creating new economic hazards that have rattled financial markets, risked

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